

GREAT GUNSMITHS

HECKLER AND KOCH

Rooted in the long tradition of German firearms manufacture, Heckler and Koch was founded by three former Mauser engineers after World War II. A major contract to provide a rifle for the German Federal Army brought the company early success, and it has been a significant force in weapons production ever since. Products such as the G3 and HK33 rifles have sold very widely and spawned numerous variants, making the Heckler and Koch brand one of the most familiar in the world of weapons.

THEODOR KOCH



In the years following World War II, the Allied forces (UK, US, and others) put severe restrictions on industry in Germany and, although some of these curbs were soon lifted, the ban on arms production remained well into the 1950s. The Mauser weapons factory at Oberndorf was shut down by the French occupying forces, but three former Mauser employees, Edmund Heckler, Theodor Koch, and Alex Seidel, salvaged some of the machinery. All three were seasoned engineers with experience in firearms manufacture and the metalworking industry, and they needed all their skill and adaptability in the tough economic conditions of postwar Germany. Their new business—originally named after Heckler, but renamed Heckler and Koch—began as a manufacturer of bicycles, machine tools, and precision parts for items such as sewing machines. Many of their workers had formerly been Mauser employees.

▼ OBERNDORF FACTORY

Part of the Heckler and Koch factory at Oberndorf, Germany, consisted of low-rise prefabricated buildings put up in the period after the end of World War II.



“The MP5 deserves its reputation for excellence.”

CHRIS MCNAB, **THE SAS TRAINING MANUAL**

IN THE BEGINNING

When Germany began to reconstruct its economy after the war, there was a large demand for the items originally produced by Heckler and Koch. But the founders' roots were in the firearms business and they waited patiently for a chance to return to the industry in which they had once flourished. The opening did not come until the mid-1950s, when the ban on weapons production was finally lifted. The big opportunity for Heckler and Koch arrived in 1956, when tenders were invited to produce a new assault rifle for the infantry of the German Federal Army. The successful weapon was based on a rifle that had been developed at the old Mauser factory in the 1940s, before being modified by the Spanish design and development agency CETME and then refined

still further by Heckler and Koch. The army preferred their design to the competitors' on offer at that time—one rifle from America and another from Switzerland—and in 1959, Heckler and Koch were awarded a contract to produce the rifle, which became known as the G3 (see p.243). The G3 was based on a roller-delayed recoil action developed by the engineer Ludwig Vorgrimmler. The weapon has a modular design, allowing the user to swap parts at speed to reconfigure the rifle. In addition, Heckler and Koch made a host of variants on the basic design. Versions with different trigger groups, sights, stocks, deflectors, and other parts have been produced, making the G3 highly versatile and helping it to become widely used.

ADVANCES IN TECHNOLOGY

The G3 provided Heckler and Koch with a hugely successful start in firearms manufacturing. Armed forces from Norway to South Africa have bought it, the weapon has seen service all over the world, and some models remain in production today. It also provided the basis for further firearms that proved highly successful for Heckler and Koch. There are four main groups of these, each sharing the G3's roller-delayed action, but each chambered for a different cartridge and consisting of a large subfamily of weapons. A prime example is the MP5 submachine-